

Jaguar

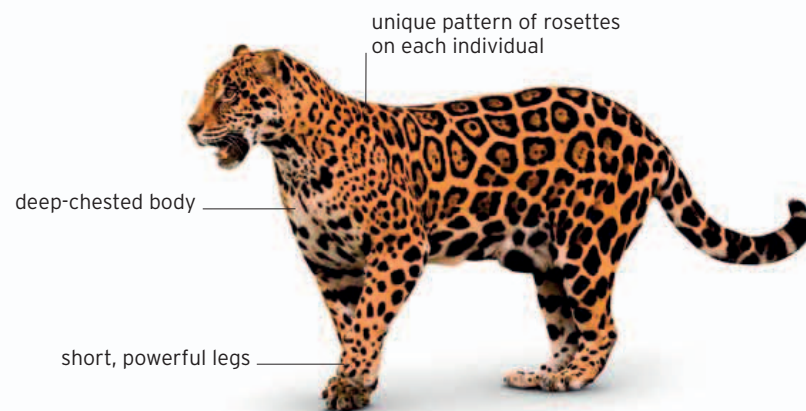
Panthera onca

The western hemisphere's largest feline is the least well-studied—scientists have no idea how many jaguars are left in the wild. This secretive cat once roamed forests from the southwestern US to Argentina, but it now occupies only about 45 percent of its original range, due to human intervention. Today, it is confined to 19 Latin American countries.

Formidable predator

The epitome of the opportunistic hunter, jaguars feed on a range of mammals, from deer and peccaries to coatis and monkeys. They also eat insects, fish, birds, caimans, anacondas, and eggs. There has been just one, recent, instance of a jaguar eating a human; however, when faced with habitat loss due to human encroachment, they will prey on livestock and domestic pets.

An efficient predator, the jaguar's immense jaw strength allows it to pierce the skull of its victims. It usually hunts at dusk or dawn, when its dappled coat provides maximum camouflage, but is more nocturnal where people are present. An adult male needs about 100 sq miles (260 sq km) of territory to hunt—this can range from humid rainforest, dry pine woods, swamp, scrubland, savanna, to desert.



Adult male jaguars can **break through bone and turtle shell in a single bite**

Like lions and tigers, jaguars can roar, but they communicate more frequently using coughs, growls, grunts, “huffs,” and low moans.

Jaguars are solitary animals that only pair up to breed. Females give birth to one to four cubs, which are born with sky-blue eyes that turn green-gold in a few weeks. Their head and paws grow more quickly than the rest of their bodies. Cubs are independent at 15 months but may remain in their mother's territory until they are about two years old.

An estimated six percent of jaguars have a genetic mutation that gives them a “dark phase” coat color. Dark coated jaguars and leopards are called panthers, although the characteristic rosettes are still visible.



△ SKILFUL SWIMMER

Powerfully muscled legs make jaguars strong swimmers—one was seen crossing a river to attack a caiman basking on a sandbank.

▷ AT THE WATER'S EDGE

Generally considered a jungle creature, the jaguar can adapt to almost any habitat, provided there is water and prey nearby. In the wild, the jaguar's lifespan is 10–12 years.

